Europe's Ancient Forests Were Open and Sunny

From: ScienceDaily Top Environment Mined: 2026-11-08 3 min read

Picture Europe a long, long time ago. You might imagine a dark forest of tall trees stretching as far as you can see. But scientists say that picture is probably wrong.

Instead, much of Europe was open and sunny, with scattered trees, grassy **clearings**, and **meadows** full of wildflowers. Birds and butterflies lived in these bright places, and huge **plant-eating** animals kept the trees and bushes from taking over.

Researchers led by Aarhus University found that this mix of open land and **woodland** was the normal landscape for more than 20 million years. The thick, dark forests we see in many places today came much later.

The study was published in the journal Biological Conservation. It raises questions about tree-planting programs today, which often plant **dense** forests to fight **climate change** and protect wildlife.

Professor Jens-Christian Svenning of Aarhus University, who led the study, says planting only **dense** forests could harm wildlife, because Europe's animals and plants grew up in open landscapes over millions of years.

Word Treasure

clearings -- Open spaces in a forest with no trees.
meadows -- Fields of grass and wildflowers.
woodland -- Land with trees growing on it.
dense -- Packed tightly together.
plant-eating -- Animals that eat plants.
climate change -- The way Earth's weather and temperatures change over a long time.

Background you need

A long time ago, much of Europe was not covered in thick, dark forest, but was a mix of open sunny land and patches of trees.

Big plant-eating animals helped keep the land open by eating trees and bushes, so birds and butterflies had bright places to live.

Today, people often plant dense forests to fight climate change, but that may not suit the animals and plants that grew up in open landscapes.

Break it down

WHO: Researchers led by Aarhus University, including Professor Jens-Christian Svenning

WHAT: The researchers found that ancient Europe was mostly open and sunny land, not thick dark forest

WHERE: Europe

WHY: The finding raises questions about tree-planting programs, because planting only dense forests could harm wildlife

Why it matters

The parks and green spaces near your home are shaped by the same choices about trees and open land, and getting the mix right helps birds and butterflies thrive.

Test what you remember

1. What did much of Europe look like a long, long time ago?

- (A) Covered in ice
- (B) A desert with no plants
- (C) Open and sunny, with scattered trees and grassy clearings
- (D) Dark forest everywhere

2. What kept the trees and bushes from taking over?

- (A) Huge plant-eating animals
- (B) Birds and butterflies
- (C) Wildflowers
- (D) Researchers

3. Which university led the research?

- (A) North Carolina State University
- (B) Cambridge University
- (C) Aarhus University
- (D) Oxford University

4. In which journal was the study published?

- (A) Nature
- (B) Biological Conservation
- (C) Science Daily
- (D) National Geographic

5. What do tree-planting programs often plant dense forests to fight?

- (A) Floods
- (B) Drought
- (C) Wildfires
- (D) Climate change

6. Who led the study?

- (A) Professor Jens-Christian Svenning
- (B) Professor Marie Curie
- (C) Professor Albert Einstein
- (D) Professor Isaac Newton

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Professor Jens-Christian Svenning: Planting only dense forests could harm wildlife, because Europe's animals and plants grew up in open landscapes over millions of years.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):